Knowing that there was no escape, I slowly turned to face him, with my gaze fixed on the ground. The muscles of his face twitched as he saw my bruised cheek. He lifted my face, turned it slightly to the left for a better look at the injury.

'If only you had listened to me and kept the helmet on,' he spoke softly.

Tears of repentance filled my eyes. 'I'm sorry, Papaji,' I finally broke into tears. 'I was wrong. I'm sorry. I should have listened to you. It hurts really badly.'

Papaji said nothing and hugged me. He took me inside, cleaned my wound and applied an antiseptic, poured me a glass of hot turmeric milk and sat beside me. The only thing I still remember him saying is this—*Before you learn to do something, learn all the ways to not do it. Remember, safety is paramount.*

* * *

The sudden memory of this incident sparked my instincts and I felt like I knew what I had to focus on: safety procedures and safety checklist. The exam was scheduled to start at ten in the morning. The cadets were supposed to be seated at half past nine. Question papers were distributed ten minutes prior, as everyone sat anxiously in wait. When the examiner approached my seat with the question papers, I immediately started to go through the questions. To my surprise and relief, a major chunk of the question paper was on the topic I had thoroughly prepared for—safety procedures. I scribbled on the answer sheet continuously throughout the two hours of the exam. It was over sooner than I had expected, and I was pretty pleased with my performance. I looked at Anuradha, who was seated in another corner of the examination hall. Seeing her signature cheerful smile, I knew the exam had gone well for her too. Results were announced two days after the exam and all the flight cadets had passed.

Now that we had qualified to fly, the allotment of squadrons for flight cadets was the first thing on the schedule. There were four squadrons, numbered from one to four. I was allotted Squadron Number 2. Five to six